



Fan-favourite: Alireza Firouzja played a pivotal role in Triveni Continental Kings' title victory this year. Here, he is seen surrounded by enthusiastic fans.

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

best players in the league.

The award for the best Player of the Tournament, however, went to Nihal Sarin. **On the Prodigy board, the 20-year-old from Kerala lived up to his reputation as an exceptional player in speed chess.** It should do a world of good for his confidence too.

The others among the fabulous four of Indian chess — D. Gukesh, Erigaisi and Praggnanandhaa — had all moved a little ahead of him, but he showed what a tremendous talent he is. Admittedly, this was not classical chess — a format in which he needs to work harder.

Sarin, though, was involved in a controversy: he had claimed a draw in his game against Daniel Dardha of Alpine SG Pipers, and the arbiter had allowed it. However, the Pipers

lodged a complaint, and the Icon board player Carlsen tweeted, alleging that Sarin had made several illegal moves. The appeals committee, chaired by FIDE delegate Victor Bologan, ruled that the result would stay, although it felt the arbiter should have intervened earlier.

At the heart of the matter was a new rule regarding time control introduced for this edition. Normally, in competitive chess, you get an increment of time for every move you make. However, to cater to

television and ensure games finished on schedule while also increasing excitement, the organisers came up with this innovative idea.

Most of the players felt that the lack of an increment was an excellent idea, especially from a spectator's point of view, though it may have been tough on the players at times.

For instance, Sarin was in a completely winning position against Dardha but had no time. He at least claimed a draw, but Carlsen was beaten by the clock, not so much by Firouzja, despite the five-time World



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